

How to Be Authentic Without Being Yourself

****Quick Bridge:**** Authenticity does not mean unfiltered. Your "true self" is not a fixed thing you discover and then show the world. Most leaders who feel inauthentic performing their role are not hiding something real. They have just never given themselves permission to choose how they want to show up.

The Thing Nobody Tells You About Authenticity

I did a lot of theater and acting in elementary and high school.

The truth I have learned from theater, from leading teams, and from years of working with people I needed to influence: ****authenticity is about showing up how you want others to see you.**** Not who you already are.

The standard advice for leaders is simple. Be yourself. Stay authentic. Do not pretend.

The problem with that advice is it assumes your "self" at home is the same version that works in a conference room with your executive team. It assumes that charisma is something you are born with, not something you develop. It assumes that if you have to shift how you show up depending on who is in the room, you are being inauthentic.

After 15 years leading teams and coaching other leaders: authenticity does not mean unfiltered. Your "true self" is not a fixed thing you discover and then show the world.

The Authenticity Trap

Most leaders feel guilty about not being themselves at work. They tell themselves they are being fake. They wear the leadership version of themselves like a costume they have to take off at 5 PM.

What they are actually experiencing is not inauthenticity. They are experiencing the normal human skill of choosing how to show up based on context.

You do not talk to your CEO the same way you talk to your closest friend. You do not present your ideas in a team meeting the way you present them in a 1-on-1. You do not communicate frustration the same way to your partner and your direct report.

These are not lies. These are choices.

The leaders I work with who are struggling with authenticity are usually struggling with permission. Permission to choose. Permission to develop a version of themselves that works for the role they have stepped into. Permission to learn charisma as a skill instead of waiting for it to feel natural.

Here is what I realized after years of theater, years of coaching, and years of leading teams: **the more authentic leaders are not the ones who are most like themselves. They are the ones who are most intentional about who they are choosing to be.**

Authenticity as Intentional Performance

When I was starting out, I believed charisma was something you either had or you did not. I am naturally more introverted.

In groups, especially when I need to be energetic, it takes a lot from me. Charisma is a short burst for me because it exhausts me.

I could have used that as an excuse. Natural introvert, not charismatic, not the kind of leader who can command a room.

Instead, I treated leadership presence like I treated theater. I practiced it. I paid attention to what worked. I got feedback. I did it again.

I spent time reflecting on what I wanted people to perceive about me. Forthright. Honest. Not hiding anything. Not boring to listen to.

Those are not naturally who I am. They are who I chose to be.

I worked on becoming a better storyteller. I worked on presenting myself as energetic and excited about the topic, even when I might not feel that way internally.

I shifted my vocabulary to positive-connotation words. I practiced being visible in meetings where my instinct was to stay quiet.

Here is what happened. The more I put myself in this mindset, the easier it got.

Every time I showed up as the leader I chose to be, I got better at it. The discomfort faded. Now, people do not believe me when I tell them I am introverted.

They do not believe it because I have spent years practicing being someone else until it became natural.

I still need a few hours alone after a full day of meetings. Before any big presentation, I still have to make the call: full energy today.

That part is just how I am wired. It is not going away.

What stopped was the guilt. I stopped telling myself I was faking something.

How to Start Choosing Instead of Being

Here is what shifts the mindset.

****First, separate**** the person from the role. You have a self. You also have a role.

The role is not your self. The self is not the role. You can be an introvert in your natural state and a visible leader in your role.

Both things are true. Both are you.

****Second:**** Get specific about who you are choosing to be in this role. Not generic. Examples:

- The person who listens more than they talk
- The person who asks the sharp question in the room
- The person who stays calm when everyone else is reacting
- The person who gives people credit publicly before they think to ask

Choose deliberately. These are not competing options. You practice more than one over time. Start with whatever is most visible right now, and be specific enough that you could describe it to someone else.

****Third, practice**** that version intentionally. You would not go on stage without rehearsal. You would not play a musical instrument without practice.

Why do you expect leadership presence to feel natural on the first try? It does not. You practice it. You get feedback. You notice what works. You do it again.

****Fourth:**** Notice when it starts to feel real. At some point, the choice becomes automatic. You stop having to think about it.

The version of yourself you are choosing to be becomes who you are. That is not when you have finally become authentic.

That is when you have practiced long enough that the choice feels natural.

[object Object]

Monday Action

This week, write down one specific version of yourself you are choosing to be in your role. Not a personality shift. Not a values change. A presence choice.

Something you can practice.

Then look for where you are already doing this naturally, even in small ways. Where are you already choosing this version. Build from there.

> ****You do not have to be yourself at work. You have to be intentional.****

Feel free to reach out if any of this resonates.

When you stop trying to be your "true self" and start choosing how you want to show up, what becomes possible?

You're great at the work. Let's make you impossible to ignore.

If you are looking for help developing intentional leadership presence, consider reaching out.

[jessstaffordcoaching.com](https://www.jessstaffordcoaching.com)

****Tags:**** Leadership, Management, Professional Development, Career Advice, Communication

****Feature Image Prompt:**** A leader standing at the front of a conference room, mid-presentation, with thoughtful but confident expression. Modern office setting with large windows and brand blue #100299 accent lighting. Minimalist, professional, human.